Workshop Exercise: Argument Extraction: Shafer-Landau on Relativism

Excerpt from:
Shafer-Landau, Russ (2004), *Whatever Happened to Good and Evil?*
New York: Oxford University Press.

[Instructions/advice are on the next page.]

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p.38 A contradiction is a claim that is simultaneously affirmed and rejected, and so is said to be, at the very same time, both true and false. Any theory that generates a contradiction is false. This is a fact recognized in every discipline. If a theory yields a prediction that a heavy body will fall to the earth at a rate of seventy feet per second, and also that the same body, under identical circumstances, will not fall to the earth at that rate, then that theory needs adjustment (at the very least). As it stands, the theory cannot be true, precisely because it generates contradictory results.

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p.43 Relativists are especially vulnerable to the charge that their theory generates contradiction. To see why, we need to ask a question that, to all appearances, seems trivial. Here it is: Can an act be performed in more than one society at a time, or is every action performed in just a single society?

The question certainly seems pointless. Or very easily answerable. It might appear that any given action—not a kind of action, but a specific, individual action—occurs at a particular time and place, and so occurs in just a single society. Relativists would love it if this were true.

Before we find out why, let me give an example to describe the kind of worry I'm thinking of. Suppose Luca Brasi receives orders from on high. Don Corleone assigns the hit, and Luca takes care of it. Where did the killing take place? In particular—which society did the killing occur in? Well, suppose it happened under the Brooklyn Bridge. Does that answer our question? Maybe. The bridge is located in the United States, so the killing occurred there. But it also occurred in New York. And in Brooklyn. OK, no problem yet. Even if we grant that these are each distinct societies, each of their social codes condemns Luca's act. p.43

Yet it seems to make sense to speak of Luca's act as one that occurred within Mafia society, governed by the Mafia code of conduct. It isn't that great a stretch to speak of a Mafia culture, with its own ethos. The rules that comprise this ethos were regarded by many as *the law* that governed their lives. Obedience to this code, and so to the word of the Don, was simply understood, essential to a way of life that Luca, his family, his friends and relations all participated in. p.44

Now the problem is acute. For if this description of what occurred is correct, then there is, after all, more than one society in which the killing took place. And these societies—Mafia society, on the one hand, and Brooklyn or U.S. society, on the other—issue different verdicts about the hit. If an action's moral status is determined, as relativists insist, exclusively by the conventions of the society in which it was performed, then relativism lands us in a contradiction. For Mafia society approves of the killing; the U.S. codes do not; and therefore the action is both right and wrong. That is a contradiction.

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There are subcultures located within any pluralistic society. And this creates a real problem for relativism, because we need to know, in such a case, which of these cultural codes is going to take precedence when it comes to making moral appraisals. The relativist tells us that an act is right if and only if it is permitted by the ultimate conventions of the society in which it is performed. But if it is performed in more than one society, it is governed by more than one code. When their elements conflict, there is contradiction. p.44

Instructions: Your aim in these exercises is to fill in the framework on the right side of this page. Essentially, you are writing a mini essay that is based on the brief text provided! Here is some advice (or direction) about what I'm trying to get you to do:

(1) **Background:** Don't worry too much about this item. It's mostly there to remind you that, if this were a real essay, you would want to set up the topic for the reader. For instance, you might use this space explain to the reader what the theory of relativism says, since that's what Shafer-Landau's text is about. (You could also use it to describe a thought experiment, if there is one that is relevent to the argument.)

(2) **Stating the argument in outline.** Here you want to briefly lay out the argument's conclusion, and the main premises of the argument. Ideally, you could do this with three or four sentences. (I try to give you simple arguments for these exercises. But arguments can have many more premises).

(2.1) Although it is standard to write **the conclusion** *last* in an argument outline, it's usually a good idea for you to begin by trying to understand what the author's conclusion is (or is supposed to be). That is, when trying to work out what the author's premises are---i.e., the claims that they are relying on to convince you of the conclusion---it helps enormously if you know WHAT they are trying to convince you of.

(2.2) Next, you want to identify the **key premises** that the are offering in support of their conclusion: What reason (or reasons) are they giving you for believing or accepting their conclusion? Sometimes, the author could be relying on a premise that is unstated---perhaps they think its obvious and no one will dispute it. But it's stil good for you to make those unstated premises explicit. Sometimes they are more controversial than the author realizes!

(2.3) If you've identified the conclusion and one or more premises, then you can write them into the section on the right that says "State the argument in outline". (Again, it's standard to write the conclusion last when givingan argument outline).

(3) Rationales for the Premises. In many cases (though not all cases), there is more to be said about a premise. In this section of the worksheet, you can expand on that, if need be. For instance, does the premise make use of a technical term in philosophy? If it does, you can define that term here. Or perhaps the premise in quesition asserts a connection between two ideas. In that case, the rationale might involve explaining why the one idea follows from the other. Etc.

(4) Evaluation of the argument. Here, the question is whether you found the argument convincing or not. If you *did* find it convincing, there might not be much to say in the evaluation section. But if you weren't convinced, this is the place to say what you think is wrong with the argument: (A) Does the conclusion not follow from it's premises? (B) Does one (or more) of its premises seem doubtful to you? Why? (Even if you agree with an argument, it's a useful exercise to try to imagine why someone else might reasonably reject it.)

Background / Set up

State the argument in outline

Explain Any Rationales for the Premises

Evaluate the argument